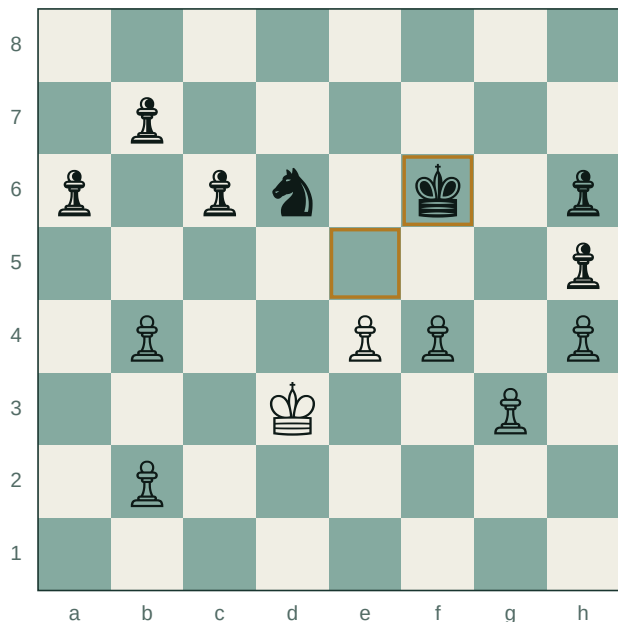


Knight-ending routes: White, move 45

Knight-ending routes

White to move



Previous move: 44...Kf6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

45. e5+ Ke7 46. exd6+ Kxd6 47. Kd4 Ke6 48. Kc5

45.e5+ Check restricts Black to 6 legal replies here. From e5 it attacks king on f6 and knight on d6. Recorded reply: **45...Ke7**.

46.exd6+ Check restricts Black to 8 legal replies here. The move also takes the knight on d6. Recorded reply: **46...Kxd6**.

47.Kd4 The king moves from d3 to d4. Recorded reply: **47...Ke6**.

48.Kc5 The king moves from d4 to c5.

At the end, nominal material is White 5 / Black 5 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +2:** the balance goes from -2 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A knight changes color with every move and may need a detour. Check the route square by square before trusting a race estimate.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Knight endings reward exact route calculation. Forks can change a pawn race, while a distant passer may outrun the knight's short-range movement.

HOW TO LOOK

Map the knight's checking moves and its route to the critical blockade square. Count moves rather than judging distance by appearance.

The defending king is on f6. Geometrically undefended: knight on d6. Check for tactical protection.